facilities and requiring every medical school graduate to spend a year doing social service work in an underserved rural area. Dental service was added in 1961.[16] Like education, improving access to health care was not seen as a technical problem, but rather as a revolutionary transformation of society.

The overt hostility of Cuba's powerful neighbor, the United States, to the revolutionary process contributed to the sense that the Revolution had to continue with a state of mobilization and alert even after the military victory. In late 1960, in the context of ongoing attacks and sabotage – which Castro called "imperialist campaigns of aggression" – the Cuban leader called for the population to "set up a system of revolutionary collective vigilance." "When the masses are organized," he exhorted, "there isn't a single imperialist, or a lackey of the imperialists, or anybody who has sold out to the imperialists, who can operate."[17] The response was the creation of the CDRs or Committees for the Defense of the Revolution.

"The first committees began to form almost immediately following Castro's speech, despite the absence of official guidelines for the program," explains Richard Fagen. "Groups of enthusiastic citizens went ahead and organized their own committees without much attention to procedural niceties. Like so many other institutions of the early years of the Revolution, the first CDR displayed more energy than order, more enthusiasm than discipline."[18]

The Revolution called on everybody to participate in creating the new society. The CDRs carried out the country's first vaccination campaign, in 1962. They supported the implementation of the Literacy Campaign. When the U.S.-backed exile army invaded Cuba at the Bay of Pigs in April, 1961, the CDRs were ordered to round up counterrevolutionaries and their sympathizers. "While the Revolutionary Armed Forces and the Militia were engaging the exile troops … the committees, in a frenzy of activity in the cities and towns, were reporting and rounding up persons suspected of counterrevolutionary sentiments and behavior."[19] Although tens of thousands were detained – often on flimsy evidence – most were released when the three-day invasion was decisively